



Celina Jaitley, 28, Actor

The actor regresses into three lives. In one she's a soldier who's stabbed, in the next she's happily married but dies in a car accident. Her stomach ache is because of being stabbed.

"I had a loving husband in my past life. I'm waiting for my soulmate."



Kulwinder Kaur, 22, Student

As a 16-year-old, Kaur got burned during Lohri. She told her parents that she had been burned once before. When regressed Kaur says her mother-in-law had burned her alive.

"I was burned for dowry. That's why I fear marriage."



Shalini Kingarh, 24, Homemaker

Ever since she was five, Kingarh has had a crippling fear of the festival Holi. On the show she saw herself being chased by five men and ending her life on that day.

"I would tremble whenever there was a knock on the door on Holi."

not established." Extremely skeptical about a person recalling images from his past life, Shetty says there are institutes that "teach" past life regression in just three days. He insists that the images people see are nothing but vivid fantasy.

Instead of replying to criticism, Dr Jayin from *Raaz...*, scrolls down messages on her mobile phone that are from people who were on the show and have been healed. One of them is Punjabi actor Mannat Singh, who couldn't understand why her left shoulder ached unbearably. On the show she sees flashes of being shot as a freedom fighter. "There will be non-believers. But that is fine," says Jayin. For the last two decades, Jayin, 48, has been a therapist at a psychiatric hospital. Sudipta Basu, the producer of the show and head of Ideas Box, is Jayin's school friend and also underwent PLR. That is how the idea of the show germinated.

Hypnotherapist Tarun Cherian, 45, from Bangalore has his reservations. "I haven't seen the show, but it sounds horrific," laughs Cherian, adding that TV demands sensational stories. He explains that unlike what the show projects, PLR is not a panacea for every problem. Also, half-baked information is dangerous. "How is the knowledge that you were raped in your last life going to help? It's only going to make you feel worse," adds Cherian.

The fact that hypnosis is carried out on a set with lights and camera crew has also left many questioning its authenticity. "When you know there is someone watching, the mind only tells you what you want to hear," says Reddy. Dr Jayin, however, stays firm that all cases are authentic. Many viewers have even been left befuddled by the speed with which participants fall into a hypnotic sleep. But Jayin says that's edited for TV. In actuality the process takes two to three hours.

“These shows are capitalising on excitement. It's nothing but voyeuristic viewing.”

RAJESH PARIKH,
Neuropsychiatrist,
Jaslok Hospital, Mumbai

Not many know that the show's call centre only shortlists callers with the most dramatic story. As soon as NDTV Imagine opened the phone lines, they received more than 600 calls daily. If someone called with a fear of water or roaches, however, they didn't cut it. But if someone like Lalita from Orissa called with a crippling fear of a metal scrubber, they would be on. That is the problem Dr Rajesh Parikh, neuropsychiatrist at Jaslok hospital, Mumbai, has. "These shows are commercially capitalising on something that would excite the viewer. They are voyeuristic," he says.

Some medical practitioners, though, have found a middle path. Dr Newton Kondaveti, founder of Life Research Academy in Hyderabad and who taught Jayin, is a qualified medical practitioner as well as a PLR therapist. He says his training has never resulted in a conflict. "Even medical science now agrees on the importance of the power of the mind. With PLR, we have only taken it further," he says. The non-believers, however, have labelled the show and the therapy irresponsible. "When India is trying to be scientific, this is highly regressive," Jayashree Ramadas, dean, Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education, Mumbai, was quoted as saying. Besides it's dangerous too. Anyone with a mental condition, especially psychosis or schizophrenia might only get worse.

Fantasy or fact, soap or reality, whatever one might call it, there is no dismissing it. Past life or anything that exists beyond our realm of understanding will continue to elicit interest. The only fear is that with shows like *Raaz...*, the need to shock on TV will only increase. "The more private we are becoming, the more we are getting excited about peeping into other people's lives," says Parikh. First people unearthed the *sach* on TV, then they tied the knot; they've now explored past lives. How long before television pushes the boundary yet again? ■